

The GREAT PRETENSE

A CALL TO LOVE
THAT **COSTS** SOMETHING.



Introduction: I Found None — Not One



There is a passage in the book of Ezekiel that has refused to leave me alone.

In chapter twenty two, God looks down at his people and what He sees breaks His heart. The prophets are lying. The priests are corrupt. The leaders are devouring the people like wolves. The poor are being robbed, crushed, and pushed aside. And then God says something that should stop every one of us cold.

I looked for someone who would build up the wall and stand in the gap on behalf of the land, so that I would not have to destroy it. But I found no one. Not one.

Not one.

He was not looking for a perfect man. He was not looking for a theologian or a seminary graduate or a man with the right title behind his name. He was looking for anyone. Anyone at all who would stand up and say, enough. Anyone who would place himself between the poor and their suffering and refuse to move.

And He found nobody.

I want to ask you something before we go any further. And I want you to sit with this question and not answer it too quickly.

If God looked at the church today — your church, your city, your congregation — and He searched for someone standing in that gap, would He find you?

Or would He find an empty wall?

This book is not written by a theologian. I am not a pastor or an apostle or a man with impressive credentials. I am a man who has seen things I cannot

ot unsee. A man who has been on both sides of the gap — the side with too much and the side with nothing. A man who has been moved to tears, shamed to silence, and finally compelled to speak.

What you are about to read might make you uncomfortable. Good. Discomfort is the beginning of change. It might upset or make you angry. I understand. But I want to ask you to stay with me, because behind everything I am about to say there is only one intention.

I love the church. I love the body of Christ. And it is precisely because I love it that I cannot stay quiet about what I see happening to it.

We have become experts at pretending.

We have mastered the language of “speaking by faith” while living in the silence of need. We have perfected the Sunday performance while our neighbour starves behind his front door. We have built bigger buildings and preached louder sermons and organised greater conferences, present amazing stage performances and yet Jesus said that by our love for one another the world would know we are His disciples.

Not by our buildings. Not by our conferences. Not by our sermons.

By our love.

I am writing this because God asked me a question that I cannot escape. He asked me: will you stand in the gap? Will you build the wall?

This letter is my answer.

And now I am asking you the same question.

Chapter One: The Woman in the Single Room



I want to tell you about a woman who changed my life.

She worked in my house. She cleaned my floors, cooked my food, washed my dishes and made my bed. As a matter of fact she did my household and kept my world in order. One day I drove her home after work.

I will never forget that drive.

When we arrived, she got out of the car and walked toward a single room proudly invited me to see her dwelling. What I saw was not a flat. Not a small house. One room. That room was everything — her kitchen, her bedroom, her lounge, her pantry, her bathroom. Her entire life lived within four walls that were smaller than my lounge.

I looked at the food in that room. What I saw there could not have put one decent meal on my table. When I thought about what I spent on food for myself in a single week, I felt something shift inside me. I did not need to look at her wardrobe. I already knew. She wore the same clothes to work because they were the only clothes she had.

And I had thought I was a wonderful employer.

I was paying her a salary that could barely cover her rent, her water, and her lights. The basic necessities of survival. And I had been walking around feeling generous and good about myself.

Leaving that single room on my way home I knew. Something was deeply, seriously wrong.

But here is what I want to tell you about this woman. She could not read. She could not write. By the world's measure she had nothing — no education, no assets, no savings, no security. She was in her early seventies, walking with the difficulty of steel pins in her hip from an operation years

before. Getting up was hard for her. Sitting down was hard. But once she started moving she was fine and very movable. She could do anything even people half her age could do, and that included walking to work for about 5km in the morning and 5 km home after work. That is besides walking to church, visiting sick and needy ones and sharing what she had.

She had something that no amount of money could buy.

She had God.

She loved Him with everything she had. And what she had, she gave completely. When she prayed for me, she did not pray the polished, careful prayers of someone performing for an audience. She prayed like a woman who knew exactly who she was talking to. She would look at me and tell me how much God loved me, how much he cared for me, with a certainty that no preacher standing behind a pulpit had ever managed to put in my heart. You see, she always said: My Jesus writes and explains things for me on the blackboard like in school. She knew her Master and Saviour.

She made an impact on my life that no sermon ever did.

She used to tell me she was looking forward to heaven. Not with fear. Not with resignation. With joy. Because of the pins in her hip, she said, I am going to ride my bicycle on the golden streets and feel the wind in my hair, then I don't have to walk. I am going to see my Jesus.

I was at her bedside the day she died.

She lay on a bed with sheets so thin you could almost see through them. But there was something on her face that I have never forgotten and will never forget for as long as I live. There was joy. There was peace. A peace so real and so solid it filled the room.

She looked up and said: He has come. He is at the door to take me home with eyes beaming of light and excitement.

Then she said: "Goodbye my brother".

And she was gone.

I stood there in that room and I thought about the disparity. This woman had spent her life with almost nothing by the world's measure. She had cleaned the floors of people who lived in comfort she would never know. She had been paid wages that kept her surviving but never truly living. She had been invisible to the world around her.

And she died richer than almost anyone I have ever known. The cloud of witnesses at her funeral was a testimony of her impact on all of them during her life.

Tell me: What do YOU think?

Was it acceptable? Was it right? Was it what God had in mind when He placed her in my life and placed me in hers?

I do not think so.

I was the one who claimed to know God. I was the one who sat in church and sang the songs and raised my hands and confessed that God was my provider and that I lacked nothing. Yet I drove this woman — this woman who prayed for me and loved me and pointed me to Jesus — I drove her back home to a single room smaller than my lounge many a time and told myself I was a good employer.

That is the pretence I am writing about.

Not the pretence of unbelievers. The pretence of us. The church. The people who know better, who have more, who carry the name of Jesus Christ and then drive home to our comfort and leave the gap wide open.

God said He looked for someone to stand in that gap.

He found no one.

I am asking you today: is that still true?

Chapter Two: The Baby at the Door



I want to tell you about a Monday morning that I have never been able to forget, no matter how hard I tried.

There was a knock at my front door. When I opened it, a woman stood there holding a baby in her arms. The child was about six months old. His head was enlarged — what people sometimes call a waterhead baby. Hydrocephalus. A condition where fluid builds up around the brain and causes the head to swell. In children whose parents cannot afford the right medical care, it is often a death sentence.

She had been everywhere. Doctors. Clinics. She had spent every cent she had trying to find help for this child. She had even gone to witch doctors in her desperation, trying anything, everything, for this baby she loved. Someone had told her to come to me. That I would pray for her child.

I want to be honest with you about what happened next, because the honest version is the only version worth telling.

I was busy. I had my own things to attend to, my own schedule, my own important matters. So I stood there at the door — I did not even invite her in — I put my hand on that baby, and I said something like: Lord, in the name of Jesus, heal this child today.

Then I looked at her and said: The child is healed. Goodbye.

I turned around and went back to my own business.

I did not think about that baby again. Not once. I did not go to find out how she was eating. I did not check on the child. I did not follow up. I simply moved on, because my life was more important to me than anything else.

Eleven years passed.

I was at a gathering of believers one evening, and after everything was finished, a woman came toward me with a young boy beside her. She asked me if I remembered her. I told her honestly that I did not.

Then she told me. Eleven years ago, she said, I stood at your door with a baby in my arms.

I looked at the boy standing next to her. Tall. Healthy. Eyes bright and clear.

She said: You prayed for my son. He was healed. He has been in school, and every single year he is first in his class. He is the pride of my life and the blessing God has given me. I came tonight to say thank you.

I cannot find words adequate enough to describe what happened inside me at that moment.

I felt naked. Completely and utterly exposed. Every pretence I had about myself — about being a man of faith, about being someone God used — it all fell away in an instant. Because I knew the truth. That child was not healed because of my faith. That child was not healed because I was something special or spiritually powerful or deeply committed.

That child was healed because of a merciful, loving Father who needed nothing more from me than a willing hand and the audacity to call on His name. He used a distracted, self-important man who could not even be bothered to invite a desperate mother through his front door.

He used a donkey.

You know the story of Balaam's donkey — the ordinary animal God used to speak when the prophet could not hear. God does not need impressive instruments. He needs available ones. That morning at my door, I was nothing more than a donkey He pressed into service because I happened to be standing there.

The miracle was entirely His.

The shame was entirely mine.

I am telling you this story not to impress you with a healing testimony. I am telling you this story because of what it revealed about me. About how I treated that woman. About how little her desperation registered against my own convenience. About how I prayed and walked away and called it done without a single thought for the human being standing on my doorstep.

That is the gap I am talking about.

Not some grand theological failure. Not a doctrinal crisis. Just a man too busy with himself to truly see the person in front of him.

God healed that child in spite of me. But He is asking something more of you and me than just getting out of the way. He is asking us to actually show up. To see the woman at the door. To invite her in. To find out how she is eating. To follow up. To care.

Not because it earns the miracle. The miracle is His to give.

But because that woman is His child. That baby was His child. Every desperate person who has ever knocked on a door looking for help is His child.

He said it Himself. Whatever you do for the least of these, you have done it for Me.

Where were you?

Where was I?

Chapter Three: The Great Pretence



I want to tell you about a birthday party.

A pastor I knew fairly well was celebrating his birthday being a significant milestone, as he had now reached the age of really being an elder. He was a man who had done real work in the church — started many churches, impacted many lives and left a mark on this nation. The celebration was big. Multiple birthday events were organised. They even arranged a party for the who's who in church circles where they sold tickets to attend and obviously raise funds for him as a birthday present. My wife and I were also invited to attend at N\$2000 for us to have space at one of these tables.

What the organisers — and the pastor's wife, who kept phoning to secure our seats — did not know, and what the pastor himself did not know, was that in the midst of those constant calls to attend the celebration, we ourselves had no food for a simple supper. N\$2000 was a fortune to a family that could not even feed itself. We never paid it, and we never went, because we simply did not have it. Instead of having that money to meet our own need, I came across my wife standing in the kitchen with tears running down her cheeks, unable to make even a simple supper for our six-year-old son.

I am not telling you this to embarrass anyone. I am not telling you this to cast judgment on a pastor who celebrated a birthday. I am not telling you this to tell you even I, the one God called to minister to the poor have sometimes needs. I am telling you this because it is a picture of something that is happening all over the body of Christ, every single day — even on Sundays, in churches across every city and every nation.

The Great Pretence.

You know what the Great Pretence sounds like. You have heard it. You may have spoken it yourself. I know I have.

God supplies all my needs according to His riches in glory through Christ Jesus.

I have an abundance. He is my Shepherd. I shall not want.

It is well with me. God is good – ALL the Time!

All of this spoken with confidence, with a lifted chin, with the right expression on the face — while the child at home has no food, while the electricity bill has not been paid, while tomorrow is a question mark with no answer in sight.

Why do we do this?

Because it is expected of us. Because to admit the need feels like admitting a failure of faith. Because somewhere along the way the church decided that struggle means you are not trusting God properly, that poverty is a spiritual problem you bring on yourself, that a confession of lack is a confession of weakness.

So we perform.

We walk into the building on Sunday morning and we sing and we raise our hands and we tell God and each other that everything is wonderful. Then we go home to the reality we refused to name out loud.

But here is the thing I want you to notice. While you are performing your abundance, the person in the seat next to you is performing theirs. The man three rows back is performing his. The woman at the end of the aisle is performing hers. An entire congregation of people sitting together, separated by pretence, each one silently carrying what nobody is allowed to say. Why – because if I “declare it – I will get it” and we ALL wait for God to supply and react, while God is waiting for us to react. We are His representation. We are the image of God and He can only operate in and THROUGH us. For Him to meet us, we have to be HIM, His eyes, His ears, His hands – HIS RESPONSE to the needs.

When I read the book of Acts, I do not find that church wherever I go.

What I find in Acts is a group of people so wrecked by the love of God that they could not hold onto their possessions anymore. They sold what they had. They shared everything. Nobody among them lacked, because if you had more than you needed and your brother had less than he needed, the gap between you was intolerable. You closed it. Not because a law told you to. Because love made it impossible to do anything else.

That is not the church I see today.

Today I see a church that has perfected the language of love and abandoned the practice of it. A church that prays for revival on Sunday and drives past the same broken people on Monday without a second glance. A church so consumed with its own survival, its own programmes, its own internal politics, that it has forgotten the city it was planted in.

The pastor at that birthday celebration — and I say this with respect for the man and for his calling — did not know about the empty fridge. He did not know, because nobody told him. Nobody told him because we do not tell each other the truth anymore. We have built a culture inside the church where you present your best, you confess your victory, and you keep the struggle behind closed doors where it cannot embarrass you.

This is not the fault of one pastor.

It is the condition of the whole body.

We have become so self-centred that we genuinely do not know what is happening in the lives of the people around us. You can live next to someone for three or four years and not know their name. You can sit in the same congregation for a decade and not know that your neighbour is one month away from losing his house.

God is not looking at the size of your building. He is not checking your Sunday attendance figures or admiring your production quality. He is looking at what you are doing with the person next to you.

He said: When you visited the sick, you visited Me. When you fed the hungry, you fed Me. When you sat with the prisoner, you sat with Me. When you gave water to the thirsty, you gave it to Me.

They asked Him: When did we see You in those places?

He said: Whatever you did for the least of these, you did for Me.

If that is true — and it is — then the question is not whether you love God.

The question is what you had for supper last night, and whether you knew what your neighbour had.

The ONLY thing that will bring REAL revival is not more prayer - The Great Pretence has to end. Not because I am here to condemn you, but because Jesus is standing at the door of the church knocking, and we keep it locked from the inside because if He gets in, He will do exactly what I am describing. He will get us to see each other. He will get us to care for each other. He will tear down the performance and replace it with something real, something costly, something that looks a great deal more like a cross than a celebration.

Are you ready for that?

Because that is what He is asking for – He wants us to wash each other's feet.

Chapter Four: Where Did We Come From?



I want to tell you about a young man I sat with not long ago. He is about twenty seven years old, and he said something to me that I have not stopped thinking about.

He said he missed the church.

I asked him what he meant. He had grown up in church. He is still a believer, and he really in my observation has a passion for Jesus and the church. What was there to miss?

He said: I miss the real church.

So I asked him what he meant by that.

Then he told me this. When he was born, his mother had to work to put food on the table. She could not do that with a baby at home and no one taking care of him while she was at work. So the ladies of the church got involved. They arranged themselves amongst each other to create a roster whereby each one will take care of this baby while the mother is at work. For the first five years of his life, he had plenty of women who took care of him – who loved and shared their love for Christ into him. Two hours here, three hours there. When one woman left, another arrived. He was never alone. He was never uncared for.

He is twenty seven years old today. He lives in another country. Those women (Godly mothers) still phone him. They still want to know how he is doing. They still pray for him. They still call him their child.

I sat in front of that young man and thought: if I had grown up in a church like that, would I not have wanted the same? Would my heart not also cry out for a “real church?”

That is the church we came from.

Not a building with a programme and a stage and a parking problem. A living community of people who looked at a young mother who needed to work and said: we will take care of your child. No committee. No budget meeting. No waiting for leadership approval. Just love expressing itself in the most practical way it could find.

I also remember — and this memory is precious to me — the years after I gave my heart to the Lord. Every Wednesday night we gathered at the home of the man who had led me to Christ. Sometimes there were forty, forty five people crammed into his lounge, spilling into the dining room and the passage. There was no stage. There was no production. There was singing home made music and laughter and tears of joy and sorrow. People sharing what God was doing in their lives with a joy that was completely uncontainable. All were real. No hiding behind faith's confessions – our faith was real, because we did not need a Jesus from heaven – we had the REAL Jesus walking amongst us and being in our midst.

I do not experience that anymore.

The church grew. The buildings got bigger. The services got more professional. The lighting improved and the sound system improved and the preaching got more polished. Everything got better, by the world's measure.

Something got lost.

What got lost was the Wednesday night in the lounge. What got lost was the roster of mothers. What got lost was the knowledge that the person sitting next to you knew your name, knew your story, knew what you were facing, and was not going to let you face it alone. Those all are replaced with a mobile device. I see them every time I go to or pass a public eating place. Whole families not speaking to each other, so involved with their facebook friends and their YouTube gurus or TikTok entertainers or people they never even met in person and who will do nothing for them when they are in need. It is replaced with a pastor or preacher on a screen that never met them with the eloquence polished by AI bringing about revelation knowledge nobody

ever heard. Yet inside, they are empty and lonely and hurt. They cry out for something they don't even know what it is. Something that very mobile device can and never will answer or meet. Real Love! If you thought I have declared war on technology, then you have missed what I am trying to tell you. It is amazing what a good craftsman can do with the right tools, and so are all these tools we carry with us. A tool can however never replace the hunger the craftsman has for a job well done. We should know, the master Craftsman is at work within us and we can only fulfil His dreams as we are molded into His artwork of love, compassion and care.

Unfortunately we chose to outsource our responsibility to love one another to the institution we call the church, and the institution was never designed to carry it. The institution can gather us. The Holy Spirit has to move us. The building can hold us. Love has to bind us.

We stopped doing the hard, close, inconvenient work of actually knowing one another. We convinced ourselves that attending the same service once a week was community. It is not. It has never been.

Community is the woman who phones a twenty seven year old in another country because she rocked him to sleep when he was two years old and she still considers him her child.

Community is forty five people crammed into a lounge on a Wednesday night with nowhere near enough seats because nobody wanted to miss it, and they miss each other MORE than the "it".

Community is a mother who does not have to choose between feeding her child and keeping her child safe, because the people around her refuse to let that be a choice she faces alone.

We had that. Somewhere along the way we traded it for something more comfortable, more organised, more manageable.

It is time to go back.

Not back in time. Not to a romanticised past that we can recreate by copying the outward form. But back to the thing that drove those early bel-

ievers — the raw, costly, daily, practical love for one another that made the world stop and stare.

They turned the world upside down. Not with better sermons. Not with bigger buildings.

With love that could be seen, touched, and felt by the people who received it.

That is where we came from. It is also where we need to go.

Chapter Five: The Starfish



Everything I have said so far — about the gap between rich and poor, about the broken systems, about the church that has lost its way — none of it is easy to hear, especially if you genuinely want to do something about it.

Because the moment you start looking at the scale of what is broken, despair is not far behind.

Look at the banking system. Banks in many countries are among the most profitable institutions in the world, extracting wealth from communities through interest rates and fees that quietly drain the poor while the wealthy accumulate. There is a practice called fractional reserve banking that allows a bank to lend out far more money than it actually holds — lending the same money multiple times, charging interest each time, paying the depositor almost nothing. People pay hundreds of thousands towards a home loan, and if circumstances beyond their control cause them to miss payments, the bank takes the house, sells it, and still pursues them for the remaining debt — having already made multiples of the original loan in interest payments.

This is legal. This is the system.

Look at the political systems. Governments across the world have been promising to fix poverty, fix inequality, fix the gap between the haves and the have-nots, for generations. Not one ideology has delivered. Capitalism concentrates wealth. Socialism concentrates power. Communism concentrates both in the hands of the few who enforce it. Each system carries the corruption of the human heart that designed it.

Look at the country I live in. The inequality index — the measure of the gap between rich and poor — sits at fifty nine. The second highest in the world. Over forty percent of the people have no income. Nearly half the population lives in informal housing. And yet this nation has enough natural wealth, enough agricultural capacity, enough human potential, that if it were distributed and developed with justice, every single citizen would be wealthy beyond what most people in the world can imagine.

The systems are against you. I will not pretend otherwise. They are deeply, structurally, historically unjust. They will not be fixed by a vote or a policy or a new government.

As long as human beings do not genuinely love God — not the performance of loving Him, but the real thing that changes how you treat the person next to you — the systems will remain broken. Because the systems are built by people, and people who do not love are always building systems that serve themselves.

So does that mean nothing can change? Does that mean you are powerless?

No.

Let me tell you about a little boy on a beach.

Something had happened in the sea overnight as there was a sulphur smell then next morning and thousands — of sea animals washed out on the beach. Amongst it there were also plenty of starfish laying there in the morning sun, drying out, dying, unable to breath and get back into the water on their own.

A little boy was walking along the beach, picking them up one by one and throwing them back into the sea.

An old man stopped and watched him for a while. Then he said: Son, just leave it. There is no way you can save all of these. It will not make a difference.

The boy reached down, picked up one more starfish, held it up, looked at the old man, and said: It will make a difference for this one.

He threw it back into the sea and kept picking up more to throw them back into the sea.

You cannot fix the banking system this morning. You cannot rewrite the inequality index by lunchtime. You cannot undo decades of political failure before supper. The scale of what is broken is genuinely beyond any one person.

But there is someone in your world right now — someone in your congregation, someone on your street, someone whose name you barely know — who is that starfish. Lying on the sand. Running out of time. Hoping that someone will notice.

You cannot save all of them. But you can save that one.

Here is what I have discovered: the moment you reach down and pick up that one starfish, something happens in you. A door opens that was previously shut. Because you stopped looking at the ocean full of problems and started looking at the one person in front of you, something shifts. The paralysis breaks. The despair loses its grip.

There is another dimension to this that I must tell you.

When you reach out to help someone else, you open a door for God to move on your behalf. Not as a transaction — not as a spiritual formula where generosity earns blessing — but because that is simply how He works. He flows through open hands. He moves through willing feet. When you make yourself available to be the answer to someone else's prayer, you discover that He was already arranging answers to yours.

I am not promising you that obedience will make you rich. I am telling you that a closed fist cannot receive anything. A person turned entirely inward toward their own needs, their own survival, their own comfort, has shut the very channels through which God loves to move.

Reach out. Not because it will fix the world. Not because the systems will change overnight.

Reach out because that one person matters. Because to God, there is no such thing as a small human being or an insignificant need. Because Jesus said what you do for the least of these, you do for Him.

Pick up the starfish.

Throw it back.

Keep walking and picking up more.

Chapter Six: The Recipe



Everything I have said up to this point means nothing if it stays in the air. Ideas that do not land somewhere specific, in a real place, among real people, remain just ideas. The road from here to a church that actually loves the way Acts describes is not a mystery. It is not waiting on a new move of God that bypasses human effort. It is simpler and harder than that.

It starts with one person deciding to see and act upon it.

Not to organise. Not to launch a programme. Not to get the approval of a committee or the blessing of a denomination. Just to open their eyes and see what is already in the room.

Here is what is already in your room.

In every congregation, no matter how small or how large, no matter how wealthy the neighbourhood or how poor, there are people who have and people who have not. There are people carrying knowledge, skill, experience, and capacity that they have never been invited to share. There are people sitting on dreams that have never had anyone stand beside them and say: I believe in this, let me help you.

There are also people who are one crisis away from collapse, and nobody knows it because we have all agreed to perform our abundance on Sunday morning and keep the truth behind our front doors.

Your job — if you are a leader — is to create the space where the pretence is no longer necessary. Where a man can stand up and say: I am struggling, and the response from those around him is not embarrassment or a quick prayer and a change of subject. The response is: What do you need? What is the real challenge and who in this room can help?

That is not a programme. That is a culture. Culture is harder to build than a programme, and it outlasts every programme ever designed.

So how do you build it?

You start small. You start honest. You gather a handful of people — not the whole congregation, not a grand launch with announcements and banners — just a handful of people who are tired of the pretence and hungry for something real. You sit down together and you ask two questions.

The first question is: what do we have?

Not what do we wish we had. Not what we think we need before we can start. What do we actually have, right now, in this room? It is like a sheet of assets of skills, knowledge, experience, abilities and insight.

You will be surprised. In that small gathering there will be someone who can cook extraordinary food from almost nothing. There will be someone with twenty years of business experience who has never been asked to share it. There will be someone who knows how to fix cars, someone who understands legal documents, someone who has a gift for sitting with people in crisis and helping them find their footing again. There will be someone with a piece of land they do not use at all and won't mind making it available for the body. There will be a retired teacher who has not stopped thinking about the young people who cannot read properly or struggle with maths.

None of these people have been asked. That is the tragedy. The church has been sitting on a treasury of human capacity and calling it empty. The church is famous for asking for a handout but when it comes to real giving where it matters, we sort of neglect it and do not consider these "assets" of much value.

The second question is: who around us has need?

Not who do we assume has need. Who actually has need. This requires the kind of conversation that our performance culture has made almost impossible — the honest conversation where people stop pretending and start telling the truth. It requires a leader who goes first. Who says: let me tell you

where I am struggling, and means it, so that everyone else in the room knows it is safe to do the same.

That will be the leader who can qualify to hear the needs of those too embarrassed to publicly share their needs. When you put those two lists together — what we have, and what is needed — you will find that the matches are already there. Not perfectly. Not completely. But enough to begin. Somebody might have huge needs in their own sight, but with the guidance of the Holy Spirit those big needs can easily be cut into smaller pieces that can be handled by different masters to bring a solution.

The mother who is at home and has capacity in her day can give a few hours a week to another mother who needs to work. This is not charity. This is the roster that raised a young man who is now twenty seven years old in another country with a handful of mothers who still phone him to find out how he is doing.

The lawyer in the congregation can set aside one case in every hundred — one percent of his practice — for someone in the church who is being crushed by a legal system they cannot afford to fight. One percent. That is the cost of one percent of his professional life to stand between a vulnerable person and a system designed to overwhelm them.

The accountant can do the same or even share part of his Saturdays of say some time in the week evenings sitting with small business owners in the congregation and show them how to work with money. How to read a budget. How to price their service. How to keep the books in a way that keeps the taxman from destroying them. Knowledge that took years to acquire, freely given over a Saturday morning and a cup of coffee.

The engineer can do the same. The teacher. The nurse. The person who has been in business for thirty years and made every mistake worth making.

You do not need start-up capital to begin this. You need willingness.

There will be people in your congregation with business ideas that have never gone anywhere because they do not know that you don't need money

to start a business. Sit them down with someone who built their own business on a shoestring budget and let that conversation happen. Ideas do not need capital in the beginning. They need clarity, courage, and someone who believes in them enough to help them think and plan it through.

You will also find that some of the people who appear to have nothing have the most to offer. The woman who has survived on almost nothing for twenty years knows things about resourcefulness that no business school teaches. The man who has rebuilt his life from the ground up twice knows things about resilience that cannot be learned any other way. These people are not charity cases waiting to receive. They are uncut diamonds waiting to be seen.

I want to speak to you directly about something else. The congregational co-operative.

Imagine a group of believers deciding together that their collective capacity — their combined skills, their shared network, their pooled small resources — is enough to start something. Not a church business. Not a scheme to enrich the leadership. A genuine community enterprise that produces something of value, employs people from within the congregation who need income, and serves the broader community around the church at the same time.

It does not need to be large. A food garden on a piece of donated land, producing vegetables for the congregation and the neighbourhood. A small catering operation run by the women who can cook, supplying lunches to local businesses or events. A repair workshop where people with practical skills fix what others cannot afford to replace. A tutoring group for children whose parents cannot afford extra lessons.

These things have been done. They are being done, by communities that decided to stop waiting for a system to help them and started helping one another instead.

The church was always meant to be the most functional community in any city. The most honest, the most caring, the most practically useful gathering of human beings in the neighbourhood. Not the most impressive building. Not the most professional service.

The most genuinely human.

Now I want to say something to you if you are a leader.

The single greatest obstacle to everything I have just described is not money, and it is not the indifference of your congregation. It is control. The need to approve, to oversee, to manage, to make sure everything is done in the right way through the right channels with the right permissions.

A mother who wants to start a childcare roster in the congregation does not need six months of committee meetings and a policy document. She needs someone to say: yes, do it, we support you.

A businessman who wants to start a mentorship conversation with a young entrepreneur does not need a formal church programme. He needs someone to unlock the door and get out of the way.

Your role as a leader is not to manage the love of your congregation. Your role is to release it. To create the environment where it is safe to try things, safe to fail at things, and safe to get back up and try again. To celebrate the attempt, not just the success. To make sure that the person who stepped out and fell flat knows they are still seen, still valued, still needed.

That is leadership that looks like Jesus.

He did not manage His disciples. He unleashed them. He gave them His name, His authority, and His Spirit, and He sent them out. Not with a detailed operations manual. With love and a commission.

Go and do likewise.

One more thing before I close this chapter.

I want to address the professionals in the room. The doctors, the lawyers, the accountants, the engineers, the architects, the financial advisors. The people whose years of education and hard work have placed them in a position

of knowledge and influence that most people around them do not have access to.

The system has taught you to monetise every hour. Your time is billable. Your knowledge is a product. Your expertise has a price.

I am not asking you to give up your livelihood. I am asking you to give one percent of it away. Deliberately. Intentionally. To the person in your congregation who cannot afford what you know and desperately needs it.

One percent.

If that offends you, I want to ask you a question. Not to shame you. To get you in front of a mirror and see yourself. Who gave you the talents? Who paid for your education, tuition and training? Who made sacrifices in order for you to have what you have besides yourself? There **MUST** be somebody – because Nobody ever got where he or she is without somebody!

When you stand before Jesus one day — the One who poured out everything He had, who kept nothing back, whose love had no billing rate and no minimum fee — what will you say about what you did with what He gave you?

He gave you that skill. He gave you that mind. He opened the doors that led to those qualifications. He brought people across your path to make it happen. He placed you in that congregation among those people.

What did you do with it?

Chapter Seven: Raise Your Rod



Do you mind standing with me on the banks of the Red Sea once again? We have fled the slave drivers. We are still persecuted and we have a huge sea of waters in front of us. Some of us cannot swim. Some has small children that are holding them back of getting on the other side alive. Some have luggage that will for sure drown them because of the weight and they do not know to get rid of these extra luggage.

The people of Israel stood at the water's edge with the army of Egypt behind them. There was nowhere to go. The sea was in front of them, the enemy was behind them, and by every human measure the situation was finished.

God instructed Moses to stretch his rod over the sea.

The sea parted.

I have been thinking about that moment for a long time. Because there is a version of that story that people tell where God simply did something miraculous while the people watched. But that is not quite what happened. God said to Moses: why are you crying out to Me? Tell the people to move forward. Lift your rod and stretch it out over the sea.

God was waiting on Moses to act.

He did not part the sea while Moses stood on the bank praying for a miracle. He parted the sea in response to Moses raising his rod and the people stepping forward.

I want to tell you something that I believe with everything in me.

God is not waiting for you to have a better prayer life before He moves. He is not waiting for your theology to be more precise or your worship to be

more polished or your church building to be paid off. He is not withholding revival until conditions are perfect, because conditions will never be perfect.

He is waiting for you to raise your rod.

He is waiting for you to turn to the person next to you and ask how they are really doing. He is waiting for you to pick up the phone and call that young person who has not been seen in a while. He is waiting for you to walk across the street and knock on the door of the neighbour you have driven past for three years without stopping. He is waiting for you to sit down with the leader in your congregation and say: I have something to offer, how can I use it here?

That is your rod. Raise it.

The move of the Holy Spirit that we have been praying for, that we have been waiting for, that we have been crying out to God for in our church services — He has not been withholding it. He has been waiting for the church to become the kind of place He can move through. A place of real love. Real honesty. Real sacrifice. Real community.

He cannot move through a performance. He moves through surrender.

You say you want to see miracles. You want to see signs and wonders. You want to see the power of God demonstrated in your city the way it was demonstrated in the book of Acts.

Then build the Acts church.

Not the Sunday morning service. The daily, relentless, inconvenient, joyful, costly community of people who have decided that loving one another is not optional and not occasional. People who have looked at the cross and understood that Jesus held nothing back, and have decided that they will not hold back either.

When that church exists — when it is real and visible and unmistakeable — God will confirm it. He will move through it. He will bring the sick to it to be healed, the broken to it to be restored, the lost to it to be found. Not because of the eloquence of the preaching but because the love in the room is

so genuine and so powerful that people can feel it before a single word is spoken.

That is what the world is hungry for. Not a better argument for Christianity. Not a more professional church service. Not a more convincing theological explanation.

Love that can be seen.

I want to speak to the pastor one more time before I close.

You have a dream of a growing church. You pray for it. You work for it. You carry the weight of it in a way that most of your congregation will never fully understand.

I want to tell you something that may be the most important thing in this book.

The growth you are praying for will not come through a better strategy. It will come when the people in your congregation begin to love one another in the way I have described in these pages. When they start showing up for each other in practical, costly, daily ways. When the poor in your congregation know they are seen. When the wealthy in your congregation know they are needed for something more than their tithe. When every person in that building understands that they carry something irreplaceable, and that the body is incomplete without their specific gift, their specific story, their specific willingness to serve. It is only then that you have ploughed the field to disciple. It is only then that you have earned the right to sow and your seed will fall on well prepared soil. When you do what I shared with you, you are not catching fish and feed the hungry, you are setting up a fishing industry and let all catch fish and even provide the tax in the fish's mouth. You get a bigger responsibility of taking care, but you raise an army to help you and assist you because you get the trained generals which you need in your ministry.

People do not leave churches that love them. People do not leave communities where they are truly known. People will drive past five closer

churches to get to the one place where they feel that someone would notice if they were gone.

Be that church.

The people who came and left — and you know who they are, the ones who came forward at an altar call and were never seen again — they did not find Jesus in the building. They heard about Jesus in the building, but they never met Him there. Because He is most present not in the sermon but in the moment when one of His people leans over to another and says: I see you. I am here. You are not alone.

That is where He lives.

I want to close with the question I opened with.

God looked for someone to stand in the gap. To build the wall. To place himself between the vulnerable and the forces that would destroy them.

He found no one.

That was then. This is now. This is your moment.

The gap is still open. The wall still needs building. The poor are still among us. The lonely are still among us. The broken are still among us. The young people with gifts and dreams and no one to guide them are still among us.

God is searching again.

He is looking at your city. He is looking at your congregation. He is looking at you.

Will He find you?

Rise up. Open your eyes. See the person in front of you.

Raise your rod.

The sea will part.

A Final Word



You have read this letter. Now I have one last thing to say.

Do not put this down and move on with your day as though nothing happened. That would be the greatest pretence of all — to be moved for a moment and then return to exactly what you were doing before.

Go to God. Not to me. Not to a programme or a plan. Go to Him and ask Him plainly: what do you want me to do? Where is my gap? Who is my starfish?

He will answer you. He always answers that question, because it is the question closest to His heart.

If you are a leader — a pastor, an elder, an apostle, a deacon, whatever your title — ask God what He wants you to do within your congregation, your community, your city. He will show you. He will give you the plan. He will provide what is needed. Your job is to go on your knees first and then get up and move.

If you are a member of a congregation, you also have a responsibility. Share this letter. Send everyone you know to ezekiel2230.com where they can download it for free. Put it in front of your pastor and your leaders. Pray for them — pray that God moves on their hearts to act. Pray that the pretence ends and that real love begins in your church.

You have read this now. You know. That means you carry a responsibility you did not carry before you opened this letter.

You have no excuse to simply brush it off.

Go. Do something. Love somebody. Stand in the gap.

The God who found no one is still looking.

Make sure He finds you.